Idea #0

Reed woke up to discover that the world was shaking. Gnomes clad in emerald-coated bronze flakes whisked by in the opposite direction, closely followed by the chubby fluffs that were slower by nature, but making their best effort to catch up. She, on the other hand, was at a standstill, with not a hope of catching up. Was there a dog in the midst of the fields also still, staring into her confused soul with an expression of amusement?

She blinked. The bus hit another lump on the highway, making her stomach lurch, sending a shockwave of puke-tendency almost right up to her throat. The leathery odor of the bus-interior and the lingering scent of barbecue-flavored chips were not helping by pillaging subconscious attention. Why in the world, she thought, did boring 5th grade field trips have to exist?

She looked back out the window at the bushes and clouds racing along the distant mountains, and was for once glad that the other kids snacking and gaming on their phones couldn't be aware of the dressed-up gnomes and cloud fluffs that, among many other queer images, often made their way into her head. Then she saw the dog again, this time much closer. She looked away.

Reed was old enough to know that one is supposed to either be fulfilling a healthy dose of socializing or reading. The former wasn't really an option in said case—Reed was the only one sitting more in front due to chronic bussickness, the others entranced by their screens and probably not even aware of her existence. So she looked down at the book she brought along and laid on her lap: *The Beginner's Guide to Data Structures and Algorithms*. Then all the text and illustrations blurred as the bus slammed on brakes to a halt, almost thrusting the book out of her hands

and sending a shockwave of sour-bitter gulp up from her stomach. She barely held it in. Obviously not a time for reading about time complexity.

She looked at her watch for what felt like the fifth time in what felt like eternity but actually turned out to be only three minutes. Two more hours to go, with nothing else to occupy her mind. Reed couldn't imagine how she could survive.

She was bored. Reed hated being bored. Losing lifetime was bad enough, but knowing a full to-do list yet stripped of the privilege of pushing forth with tasks was a whole other excruciating torment. Like losing a race, losing a competition, losing in life! *Loser!* spoke the voice in her head.

Reed began wondering along the stream of consciousness, imagining how much more accomplished she would have been if all the time spent being bored could instead be time spent doing useful things. She wondered whether humanity as a collective would have landed people on Mars or cured cancer if boredom-time was put to better use. She was envisioning a future where AI cured boredom when there was a vociferous "Woof!" followed by a bang as the weird dog ran straight into her window.

For six seconds straight, she stared dumbstruck into the animal's face that was textured like origami, but with fur. Every feature was delineated by folds and creases that seemed almost alive and flowing, with a pair of googly eyes that almost stared straight into her soul.

By the time she recovered from the shock, Reed was yet again shocked to discover that she was no longer in the bus.

She was in a circular room with pieces of low furniture oddly dispersed through the space. They were iridescent under the ever-changing light like opalites, yet very comfortable. Were there walls? Reed thought it looked more like a translucent barrier. Light refracted at what seemed like where water met air but still tried to flow in all directions. She was seated on one of the opalite beanbags. Across from her was the dog, then a door opposite from her directly behind the dog. She could hear a faint yet consistent popping noise from beyond. Was someone making popcorn? Or was it someone playing with an excessive amount of bubble wrap packaging? She couldn't tell.

The dog barked before she formed the thought "where am I?", and Reed was suddenly aware with stunned realization that she also spoke Dog. The growling, two barks, more guttural sounds followed by more barks and yells of varying frequency and amplitude automatically deciphered themselves into the message "Woof Reed! Good to have human again. Mod happy." The dog stuck out its tongue and wagged its tail, making the googly eyes jiggle in their sockets. Then it turned, and burst out the door, leaving Reed in sole company with her confusion.

Reed got up and hobbled along, noting that her legs were numb from an extended duration of sitting. She decided not to lose track of where Mod the dog, seemingly the only living creature she encountered in the mysterious place, was headed.

"Not a bad idea."

A voice from behind Reed made her jump. It was deep and reassuring, yet it sounded like it came from a young boy no more than her age. The more uncanny realization was that the voice was extra familiar. Reed had the impression that the voice had been recurring and speaking into her mind for years. She turned, but

there didn't seem to be anyone at first. Then after her senses seemed to kick back into operation, there stood the figure looking right at her.

Reed knew that he was a friend right there, fully materialized, yet also seemed to bear the dreamlike quality of not having fully defined features. Nothing about the character seemed to register when Reed looked at him directly.

"Hang on, I know you," said Reed, "Who are you again?"

"Ask yourself." He shrugged, in the vague yet encouraging, always reassuring way.

Memories where he would mutter the answers to her during spelling tests floated back to Reed. The playground swings before they were taken down, how she would stand on the swings, gripping a lightsaber rolled from printing paper with the blade colored by highlighter. She always made those in pairs back in the day, one for herself, and the other always for the friend who was always there when she needed him...

"You're the Invisible Bob!" She realized.

"Just Bob." Bob smiled and Reed noticed that his features got more defined all of a sudden. He was dressed in the sporty shirt and shorts that aligned with their school dress code underneath a Jedi cloak, with the hood on. He was about the same height as Reed with mostly analogous features, though his hair was softer and more tame, as well as his round lake-blue eyes that always seemed serene, the polar opposite to Reed's gaze that was curious and demanding.

"I'm not supposing you know what this place is, or how I got here?" She asked, and Bob nodded in accordance with her expectations.

"Right. We go after Mod the dog." So she also dashed to the door, exited without hesitation followed by Bob, leaving the door in a slow yet cheery bounce rhythm.

The outside of the room was constructed out of the same opalite material, yet the iridescent glow from the soft light that emanated from every direction filled the more open space with much grandeur. Reed thought it was the central corridor of some palace at first. Then she decided it looked more like a station. The constant popping noise came from all directions, now more vivid and louder. Further down the middle "platform" they stood on was Mod the dog, wagging its tail and staring at her expectantly, with still the same mocking smile.

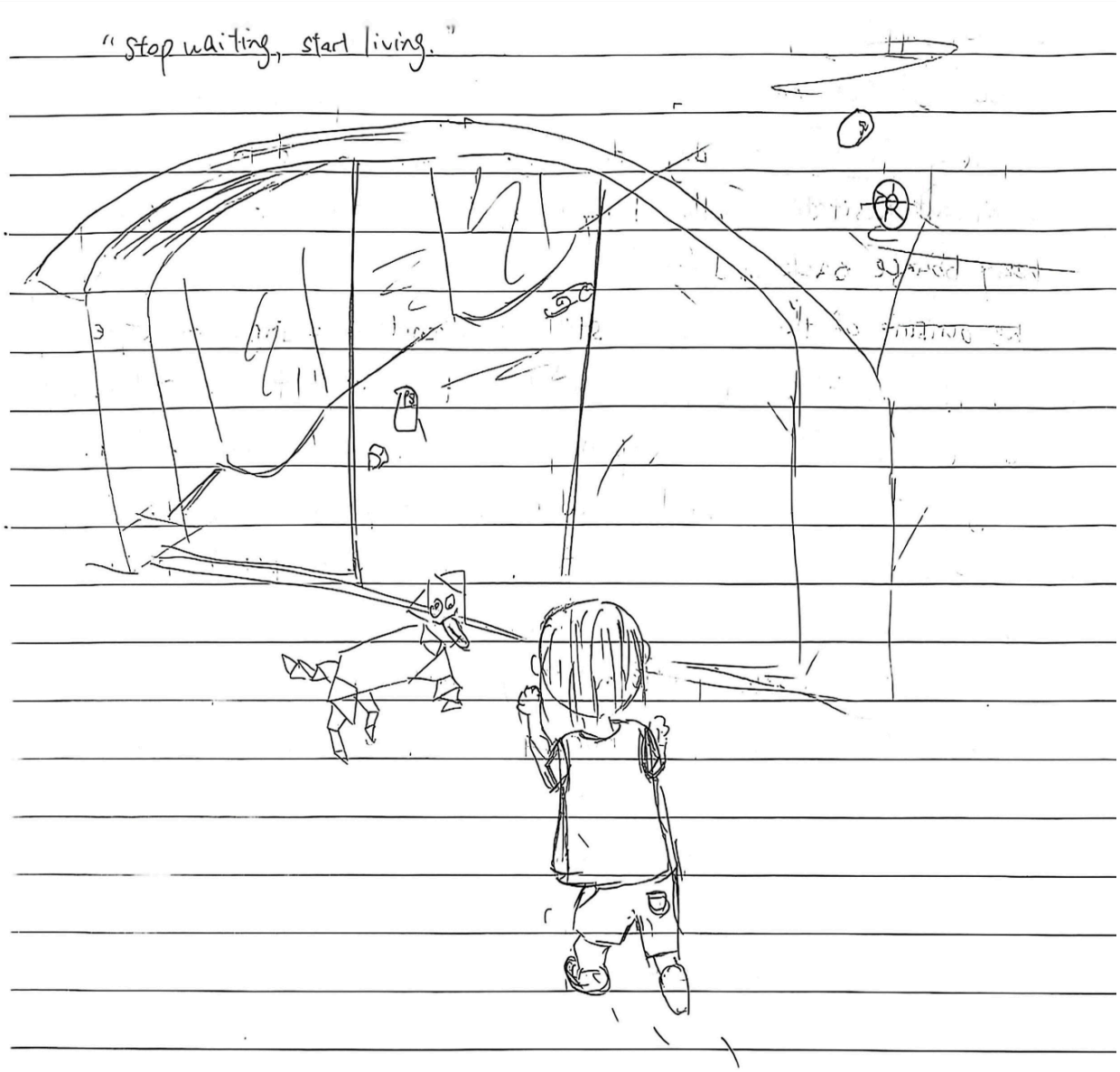
Reed had a sudden bad feeling that she was stuck in the mysterious place. "Hey doggy!" She shouted, "Where is this? There must have been a mistake, I was on a bus moments ago. How can I get back?"

"Mod!" Barked Mod, loudly. "You bored. Bored humans stay. Mod no decide."

"I'm not bored, how can I be bored?" Reed argued. Sure, she thought, she was a bit bored on that bus, but it was only temporary, merely a short wait until they would arrive—until the field trip *really* begins.

Mod's googly eyes jittered some more, drawing circles in their sockets. Then the dog bounded off further down the platform.

"Wait!!" Reed ran after in pursuit.



Reed followed the dog through an archway that seemed to border a thin translucent wall. The middle third mystified momentarily into water vapor, letting them through. The popping noise got significantly louder, as if thousands of popcorn machines were running at the same time. Unfortunately, there was no smell of popcorn, nor any in sight. In fact, the air was so much thicker that Reed felt like she was walking through clouds, barely able to see 3 steps ahead of her.

Reed was startled as the first phone zipped past in a wisp of smoke, barely missing her face. Then the shadows of a group of fidget toys sidled past, followed by a bag of snacks crunching along as if hitching a ride from some invisible wind force.

Just as she began to imagine the place as some misty gallery where eclectic daily items drifted around, a monstrously loud "POP!" went off right beside her. She almost stumbled.



Reed turned in the direction of the pop to discover a cylindrical pod had appeared, half of which docked to the edge of the platform. Within the misty pod was the figure of a nondescript man fully suited up that appeared to be seated in the dim light of the subway. The projected scene bumped gently back and forth in the pod. It tugged at Reed's curiosity until she forgot about following the dog and just stood and watched, head cocked, as the man yawned then propped his head on his forearm supported by his knee. He tapped and fidgeted with his left hand in a sleepy trance, until there was a very noticeable vibration in his right pocket. *So he joins the monotonous crowd on the subway to make better use of their time through phones, decent move.* Thought Reed.

Just as the man pulled out his phone, a metallic blur with a blinking red dot wooshed past Reed, missing her right ear by centimeters. As the phone crossed the threshold of the pod, which also happened to be the instant when the man's gaze locked on the screen, the entire pod vanished with another bursting loud POP, and Reed found herself gawking at the misty void with not a single trace of pods, suited men, or phones.

A distant bark jerked Reed's attention back to the dog. She could make out the vague shape of Mod, whose folds were blurred by the mist. Reed broke into a jog in that direction while pencils, scrolls and more phones floated in all directions with wills of their own, ignoring the constant ambient popping noises.

As she approached, she saw that Mod was sitting directly facing a pod, languidly licking its paw. Reed walked closer, and the mist thinned and dissipated. The silhouette of the figure in the pod was vaguely familiar. Vastly familiar. Realization struck as Reed rushed forth to behold a misty projection of none other than Reed herself, bumping along in a bus seat, staring aimlessly into the distance, and looking very sickly.

Mod gave a joyful yap saying "Hey, it's you!", but Reed was struck with a wave of pure terror. Her overimaginative brain assembled the images into a horror story where her soul was eternally trapped in some liminal void while all that remained in the real world was a disengaged entity that always felt faraway in spite of life's vicissitudes.

"But how do I get back!" Her voice was an octave shriller, overflowing with panic. She wanted to direct her fury at the dog, who seemed to enjoy her struggle as it stretched languidly. A scroll drifted by. Reed grabbed it from the air and hurled it at

the dog. Just as it was about to hit the dog, both the scroll and the dog seemed to shimmer and disassociate into mist. Time slowed as the scroll passed harmlessly through the dog and was then caught in a gust of wind, floating away before it hit the ground.

Disturbed as Reed was, she pieced together an idea. She intercepted a bypassing phone, scroll, another phone, and a bag of nacho cheese doritos in spite of not being a fan of them. The objects seemed reluctant to be pulled off course, tugging back and trying to escape Reed's hold. In spite of the struggle, Reed threw the first phone at the pod. It successfully passed the pod threshold, transforming into vapor.



The effects were instant. Bored-carsick-mistghost Reed looked down at her phone, and the image almost flickered, upping throwing-things Reed's hopes that everything would return to normal with a satisfying POP. Then without notice, the same phone whizzed out again to run rogue.

Reed felt like something just hit her in the shin, but she spared no attention to that as she was determined that she could use something to catch phantom-Reed's attention. She hurled the second phone and the scroll one after the other.

The phone bounced back at the invisible boundary straight at her face, and Reed barely had time to swat it away. The scroll bore more luck. As it faded into the pod, a confused expression crossed phantom-Reed's face. She cocked her head and appeared to be thinking hard...

POP

It worked! Reed thought, then suddenly became aware of the pawing at her feet and frantic barking that she previously dismissed as ambient noise from the popcorning background. Then with another POP the pod reappeared several steps to the right.

"Bad!! No... disturb natural flow in idea realm! Bad!!! BAD!" Barked and howled Mod, but Reed had already committed to attempting to shove the nacho cheese doritos into the pod again.

"Stop!!" Mod howled with the utmost urgency and alarm, but Reed was simply too determined to quit. Bob was again present to cheer her on, mouthing "you can do it!" above all the chaos.

The bag of doritos suddenly decided to lurch sideways, and Reed almost stumbled. Her flailing right hand made contact with the pod threshold in an effort to restore balance. Instantly, she was hit by a violent gust of wind that thrust her into the mist-filled pod, then she was falling, falling…



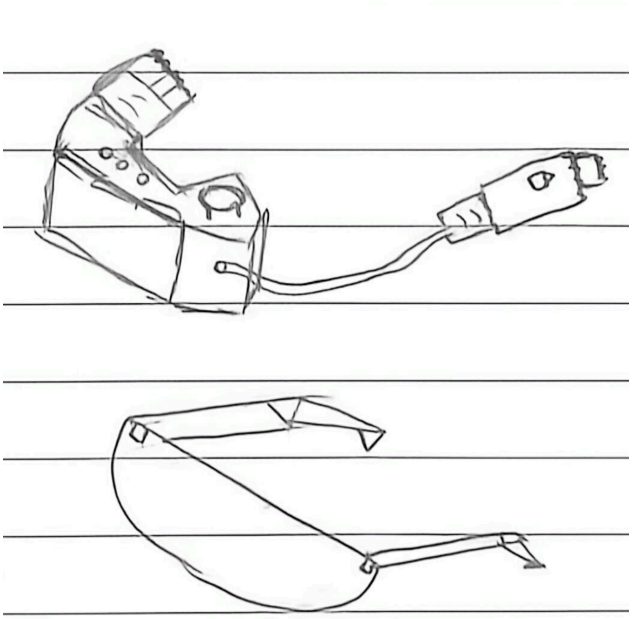
Reed opened her eyes to discover that she was on the bus again! For a joyful moment she thought the adventure through the misty opalite realm was no more than a bad dream. Then she noticed the person in the window seat to her left. That was the phantom Reed from the pod! She jumped back into the shaky bus aisle, right through the armrest. Then she realized that she was the ghost, and phantom Reed there was just as bored and existing in full material form as ever.

"Helppp!!!" Reed screamed, but no sound came out. She couldn't hold it any longer and started crying and yelling in the faces of everyone up and down the bus. She knew it was useless, as useless as it would have been if she screamed at the businessman in the subway pod, but the stubborn part of her utterly rejected rationality. Nothing made any sense at all.

"Hey." Said Bob. He reached out and tapped Reed's shoulder gently. Reed swerved upon contact, her eyes widened as she realized that Bob was made of the same shimmering misty substance. Then she heard Mod's barking coming from all around her, but she could neither locate the dog nor make out any meaning from the barks.

She closed her eyes and ceased doing anything. She would have stood still for eternity if Bob didn't nudge her again. Perhaps he could sense that Reed had given up.

She reluctantly opened her eyes again as the world came back into focus. Bob was handing her two odd-looking gadgets. Reed had a sudden flashback of when she was thrust into the pod and falling, of Mod going in a frantic circle and conjuring this duo of gadgets and throwing them to her like a rescuer making the last attempt to throw a life jacket to a drowning half-conscious person.



She took the gadgets from Bob for closer examination. Both took the form of origami, just like Mod, yet felt sturdy and solid inside. The first had a main beam with three small unlit indicator lights in a row and of course, a large red button on the end shaped like a handle. On the other end was a pointy opening where the paper was charred at the pointy tips. Tethered to the handle by a wire was another such opening, and Reed thought it looked suspiciously like a laser beam emitter. She tried hitting the big red button. No lasers blasted, fortunately and unfortunately. She wrinkled her nose in frustration, yelling "it doesn't even work!"

Bob still held the other gadget. "Maybe try these?" Reed tried on the pair of paper light glasses with the eyepieces conjoined into a thin iridescent film. She guessed that it was made out of the same material as the realm of bored people was. At first she thought the glasses just made the world look mistier. Then as she focused on

her other self sitting still bored and carsick, she noticed the outline of a pod, just as she had seen earlier back in the misty realm. A scroll drifted into her field of vision. She grabbed at it, but the superimposed image of the scroll simply eluded her palm.

Reed felt like tearing whatever veil that cut her out from the material world to shreds, but the powerlessness was simply too exasperating. "Arrrrr!" She yelled, channeling all adrenaline into the waving and stomping tantrum.

Then it came to her to try the laser blaster. She pointed the loose end at her other self and pressed the button. No lasers. She pointed the handle laser emitter at herself with some slight angle tweak out of an epiphany that the gadget just had to be made so it merged her consciousness back into the physical, yet was proven wrong again. Anger began to build up.

"Maybe try zapping other you and some drifting scroll or phone together?" Bob suggested.

This time, the gadget did react. Streams of air reached out from both ends of the tool, tethering a bypassing scroll to the gadget, the gadget to other Reed. Reed slammed down the button as a shimmering trail of steam sent the scroll shooting straight towards other Reed as the previous air-tethers oscillated like rubber bands before disappearing.

The scroll collided with other Reed's hand at such speed that Reed winced at how much it probably hurt, but other Reed seemed unaffected at first. Then she noticed how her hand twitched. No, she was tapping, to a rhythm. Reed feared that it was the beat of that corny pop song the kids in the back were singing earlier before she

realized it was the pi song! She tapped at every digit. Classic Reed behavior, she smiled with acknowledgement. Yet the vague pod she was stuck in was still there.

Finally being able to manipulate her surroundings, Reed sought out more objects to zap. Her anger subsided as she took a few steps around the bus. She sent a phone hurtling towards the clique of boys who are always obsessed with their phone games with all the shooting involved.

"I have an idea!" Said the phone addict kid the moment his forehead collided with the phone. Reed was startled by this sudden reaction and looked around in case anyone found her culpable for such mischief, but she was still invisible. The boy began spewing some gaming jargon about how all of them would attempt some level on separate devices. They became noticeably more... saturated? More material? Reed whacked at a bus chair in the hope of hitting it, but to her dismay her hand still passed right through unperturbed. Then she felt (without hearing) a



pop. She looked up just in time to catch the other two pops as the outline of pods around the gaming gang burst and dissipated.

Cool, she thought, then promptly strode back to where she was sitting in light of her new observation.

She was still tapping the pi song, now in the part close to the 300th digit. It wouldn't be long before she exhausted her memory of the 410 digits, and the gathering of more mist into a pod around her illustrated the point.

So what would be interesting enough to stimulate all my attention while on a sickening bus? Reed cogitated hard. 28 - 41 - 02! The pi song taps had a very soporific effect.

Then it came to her. Instead of mindlessly tapping along the song, why not try creating her own pi song past the 400 digits! If only there were a way to air laser-zap her mortal self to pass this idea along. Her gaze locked onto another scroll floating by, with a dangerously determined curiosity. She flipped the handle in her left hand while keeping aim with her right on the flying scroll. With a jab of the button, the air tethers streamed to life, tugging the scroll towards the ghost but consciously alive her. The scroll began to accelerate in the direction of her face. Reed wondered whether it would hurt if it actually hit her instead of passing right through her. She was ready to dodge right when the scroll twitched to a halt, then unfurled itself reluctantly, revealing a page full of indecipherable squiggles that looked like someone mistook vinegar as shampoo and wiped their hair on the poor page.

"Uh, sorry to interrupt, you're probably on your way to someone important," Reed said to the scroll, "You're free to go your way, but I'd really appreciate you telling

this one to think about pi song lyrics?" She gestured to the Reed sitting in the bus seat, still tapping, 3, 7, 2, 4…

Reed inferred that being puppeteered by two streams of air must have been unpleasant, for the scroll proved to be more obedient than the most pretentious teacher's pet. Mist curled around the scroll, then with an iridescent flash, it undulated and split in the middle. The upper scroll, still inscribed with the brown sea-urchin-like message, extricated itself from the tethers and drifted away to continue its journey. Remaining light from the flash converged into a single point darting across the second scroll, revealing an inky trail as it completed the mission. *What a crude imitation of a singing pi creature,* Reed thought. She zapped it at her bored counterpart.

Reed never had a chance to observe the new idea take root, for a yet denser haze began billowing out from everywhere all at once, clouding her vision until she couldn't even see what she was holding. She yanked the ski glasses off, but the mist was still there. She felt around on the handle and found the button.

The air stood still, as if the mist-dispersal function reached an inflection point. Then Reed could see again, but she wasn't on the bus any longer. An overly familiar desk became visible a few steps to her left, and a few moments later the haze gave way to the entire living room back home where she studied.

Reed kicked the squeaky leg of the desk. Her foot disappeared again on contact. She looked around the empty room in dismay. Why was she back home?

A few rays of afternoon sun caught the pile of workbooks stacked atop the windowside bookshelf. Outside, there was the laughter of some neighborhood friends. Reed tried to make out what they were talking about.

Reed was caught by surprise by the sound of the key turning, followed by the door opening. Footsteps.

Her mother escorted her into the living room where Reed promptly dropped her backpack next to the desk, then turned to head out again. "I'm going outside now!" She announced, but looked up at mom for approval.

Approval that used to be default, but so hard in those days! Ghost Reed crept into the kitchen to check the calendar, only to confirm that she had been sent backwards in time to when the 200 day countdown began. Back when the only event to look forward to was the field trip.

"Then what about staying on track to finish all the tasks?" Reminded her mother. Reed couldn't discern if her past self was angry or sad, but a sour lump dropped in her throat. A part of her still wanted to fight back, but that part was vastly outnumbered by the logical part of her that understood priorities. She had to go over the literary achievements of history's top 10 poets before completing the exercises of chapter 7 that would not only certainly be a part of the interview, but also just basic common knowledge that any cultured citizen should know by heart. The problem-solving technique guidebook was also waiting for her, anxiously urging her to come aboard so it could help her catch up in the race to the gateway with the problems, say, if she travelled at speed 5 while the others behind their own locked doors were all at speed 3 and she was 18 behind and the gate being 100 away, would there still be a chance for her? For the time being, the era of collecting ammunition from the purple-leaved trees for the branch and vine-made slingshots was locked away. She watched her expressionless self settle into her chair to begin unpacking. A sense of worry began to dwell. Say the countdown ended, then what? The light at the end of the tunnel? Or just another tunnel? Reed shuddered at the

notion of the laughter outside and that entire world having congealed into history for good. With a sinking feeling in her gut, Reed put on the opalite film once more expecting to see herself immured in a pod. Instead, she was greeted with utter chaos.

Hurricanes of mist fought and pillaged through the opalite station that Mod had led her through only hours earlier. Shards of the shattered stone showered straight through Reed. Reed gasped for air, yet also grateful for not feeling a thing. The tumultuous airflow carried a wounded howl that bore more melancholy than any sound Reed could imagine. She glimpsed a brown shadow caught in the vortex of a swirling hurricane.

"Mod!" She shouted, and ran towards the dog, unaffected by the phantom storms. She barged through her mortal self, desk, and then a wall, but she didn't care. She desperately reacted to intercept Mod's flailing paws, but the dog was just out of reach as the curling haze whisked it out into the gloom. Reed backed up as Mod completed another full circle in the hurricane and jumped.

The instant her hand came into contact with Mod's hindleg, the full effect of the storm—no longer phantom—was upon her, sweeping her feet out from underneath. Reed caught hold of a dent in the remaining pillar of an archway and just managed to avoid being completely swept away like a used piece of draft paper. The wind tore the glasses off her face, and she was now utterly defenseless against the apocalypse back in the realm, both hands occupied and clinging on for dear life.

That same instant when Reed caught the dog, the line of logic woven from all the memories from the realm suddenly came clear to her. Reed saw how the realm used to be teeming with swarms of new ideas that gradually diminished in number.

Now it was fully occupied by podfulls of people on their phones or possessed by screens with blank expressions, waiting for their futures that faded or were forgotten before they were actually lived. The life force holding the realm of ideas whole dwindled as regional earthquakes shattered parts of the station, leaving behind patches of stagnant misty voids. In the face of its imminent collapse, some scrolls assembled themselves into a creature, infusing their life into what became... Mod!



"I'm sorry! I understand now!" Reed called out, "But I'm just me, I can't save this thing! My life has changed, and I can't be left behind!"

Her voice was drowned out by the howling wind that seemed to darken every second. A boulder of rubble smashed into the opalite pillar Reed was holding on to, sending more shards spiralling into the storm.

"It's going to fall!" Yelled Reed, helpless in the wind. She envisioned herself being lost in the broken realm for eternity as robot Reed claimed the life that used to be hers. "I need to get back! Help!"

At first, nobody came, unsurprisingly. Then Bob was there.

"You can let go of the pillar." Bob stood, unshaken by the storm. "I'll take this and give you one last zap. It'll work."

"But what about you?" Reed's voice was barely audible. Her hair lashed against her face like thousands of tiny whips.

"I'll be there whenever you need me."

Reed took a last deep breath and let go as Bob caught the gadgets. Instantly she was swept into the tornado and yanked along by the tempestuous wind. Shards of iridescent stones dug into her skin. Reed tried to grasp for Mod's other paws, but the dog was fading away.

"It okay. Not over. You still save." All sound seemed blocked out as Mod's last message pulsed along to Reed. The storm raged ever more violently, ripping apart even the ground, but a new air tether reached out from the darkness and clung onto her back, keeping her steady. Gradually, it began pulling her back, gently yet firmly. Shards of marble stabbed at her back as the tugging accelerated, the mist curling around her face like angry current thrashing at a speedboat. Reed was

scared to open her eyes, but more scared of being oblivious to her surroundings. Are the scrolls and phones that used to travel also really scared? Or were they just glad to go with the flow, if they felt anything at all? Where were all of them now that their world was falling apart? And what would happen to Bob and Mod?

Reed began noticing shadows amidst the mist racing by. The wind still howled and lashed but she became numb to it all. The mist began to fade, and as swiftly as the change began the shadows assumed themselves as trees alongside a highway. She was back in her seat. Her back struck something solid.

Reed tapped the bus window. Tap tap.

It didn't feel real any more than when she was a ghost. The part of her that Reed imagined would be ecstatic to be real again just felt more lost and sad instead somehow. She looked outside at the still wooded highwayside landscape, but there was no sign of origami-shaped dogs.

She turned from the window and was faced with *The Beginner's Guide to Data Structures and Algorithms* again. Then her lips curled into a subtle mischievous smile as she began traversing stacks and heaps, and ended her search on some exercise pages she felt sure she'd mastered.

Reed ripped them out, and began folding the pages into a dog.

She never noticed the bus exiting the highway, nor did their teacher announcing "Everyone start getting ready! We'll be in the parking lot very soon" have the slightest impedance to her experimenting with how folds can be shaped into paws or ears.

The bus parked itself and the other kids all raced to squeeze outside, but Reed was in no hurry. She ran her fingers along the final tail fold several times, took out a pencil from her pocket, and drew a pair of googly-eyes.

"Reed, is everything alright?" She was the last kid on the bus before the absence of chattering classmates and the nauseating bus smell registered once more.

"I'm great!" Reed jumped up, grabbed her bag and swung it over her back as she dashed down the steps off the bus. The morning sun was warm on her face, and Reed took her surroundings all in. Before taking off with the group to begin the adventure, she gave her pocket a reassuring tap where a pair of dog ears stuck out.

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Comments/Background

The title

The story was originally titled Boredom, but I later changed it to more be about the realm of ideas than boredom itself. The idea was that Boredom also ends in "-dom" like Kingdom and therefore the realm is like "The boredom kingdom/realm".

Things regarding boredom

I came up with the idea of this story on my trip to Yunnan when I felt bored on a bus and started looking outside the window. I though boredom is like a station where you're just waiting for things to happen, but nobody really appreciates feeling being bored. Indeed, in modern days, the proliferation of phone usage means one feels boredom much less often. But boredom is also when new ideas collide and hence the escape from being bored to discovering something new and interesting is also reduced. Furthermore, when one is on their phones and passively receiving content, it's often analogous to being bored. So maybe from this standpoint, boredom is highly connected to "not thinking independently" or "not experiencing the present moment".

That's a vague and messy train of thought on how the worldbuilding began.

Writing style

I believe the first few pages are very good at “show, don’t tell” in a very vivid and descriptive way. Then the story degenerated into basically another fever dream. I changed the plot numerous times in the middle so the ideas expressed in the beginning and closer to the ending seemed slightly incongruous. Also, not until re-reading the pi song part did I remember that I committed myself to not degenerating the story/character building into another tech nerd drama with the pi song. Probably should switch that to something else in the second draft.

The first few pages being good were the result of listening to 3rd person limited pov favorite *the House of Hades*. Still goated and much to learn from that story.

Storytelling

This will be a notorious example in Panda writing history where the story only serves the worldbuilding instead of how a story is supposed to work where the world serves the story. There is almost no plot going on, and the characters are all very passive. Perhaps the characters being confused was subconsciously my way to explain the world without resorting to mere exposition. Anyways, the entire plot still feels like a fever dream and just not very grounded or consistent. Good worldbuilding piece, unsure if the story even exists.

This is rather similar to 2026 Panda writing formula where it’s basically worldbuilding, characters wandering around, worldbuilding, all the way to the end, then finally let’s add some emotional twists to give the world some emotion (in other words, worldbuilding). To be fair I like the 6th grade story and 2021 summer short stories better.